

Episode 98: Once Upon a Time... (60) – *COO*The Warship Stage

After saying "Summer!" it's already passed the traditional Tanabata and even crossed "Beginning of Autumn."

Everyone, late summer greetings.

...But Tokyo this summer hasn't gotten as hot as expected. Cool summer trend? El Niño effects after all?

Still, this week is Obon, so it's the week when working adults across Japan simultaneously have their short summer vacation called "Obon break."

However, unfortunately, I have no break and am working straight through this week. Weekly broadcast TV work naturally won't wait, and theatrical work is also pushing toward editing at the end of this month and voice recording early next month, with everyone forgoing Obon break for work.

My enjoyment during this period is summer Koshien high school baseball broadcasts.

High school baseball cheering brass bands are amazing every year. Mixed with old popular songs like "Nerawareta Otoko" and "Southpaw," anime theme songs are doing quite well. *Triton of the Sea*, *Space Battleship Yamato*, *Lupin III* theme, *Gundam* too. How many years ago was *Triton*? About 30 years now? (laughs)

Old anime theme songs have clear themes, energy, and that "cheering" feeling. They're also not musically difficult and suited for brass bands.

Every year some high school uses them for cheering, passed down continuously. In music or anything, good things really do remain!

Now then.

Coo: Far From Home - the story rushes toward the ending with rapid developments. Pursuing kidnapped Coo, the story moves to Tahiti, Papeete. From peaceful island scenes, the story shifts to the "city."

COO, which we'd been carefully making in storyboard order from the beginning, took about a year to reach this point.

I think we were working on this area around spring 1993. Ah, since we visited the Maritime Self-Defence Force for research in late 1992, maybe a bit later? Around when Yamamoto Nizo-san's work was nearing completion, which is why I remember having a big drinking party.

Assistant director Hiroshima-san, production manager Sakai-kun, and I were taken by Nizo-san to get completely drunk in Oizumi, then drank more at Sayama City station, then tumbled into Nizo-san's studio "Eieisha" then in Sayama City, where the still-strong Nizo-san made us drink more beer (laughs). Though he was also totally drunk, in that condition he still pulled out Moriya Suji-san's art book or something to explain to us (laughs). ...Such memories too (laughs).

The next morning, still reeking of alcohol, I swayed home on the train. The scenery from that train showed beautifully blooming cherry blossoms - so spring, early April maybe? (laughs)

Recently it's rare to spend so much time making theatrical works, but this COO ultimately took about a year and a half of actual work. Initially, the production aimed for summer 1993 release, but later moved back six months to winter 1993, December release. Delayed release naturally stretched the schedule (laughs), finally completing in October I think.

So from this Papeete section to the ending's nuclear test prevention ~ parting with Coo took about half a year to create.

And the story from Papeete onward:

In crowded Papeete, underwear-like T-shirts & shorts with sandals wouldn't work. Tetsuro father and son appear in somewhat "city-appropriate" clothes (ultimately Tetsuro wore "slightly better shorts" (laughs)).

Yosuke boyishly wears T-shirt + shorts, but we decided to dress adult Tetsuro properly in a collared shirt. Cathy wears a white dress. While Yosuke was fine, Tetsuro, uncomfortable in his usual collar-less shirt, keeps fussing with his neckline. I dressed the tanned characters in whitish clothes to emphasise their tan. Locals mostly wear coloured shirts. Incidentally, at the airport scene, the contrast with the group of young Japanese tourist women who just arrived, still with their untanned white skin, looked good.

Such white clothes only for Papeete. Soon they change into different outfits. The group pursues the warship holding Coo to Mangareva Island. From here, cruisers and warships become the stage, so the screen atmosphere becomes considerably harder.

The earlier location scouting and Maritime Self-Defence Force destroyer research proved very helpful. Having seen the real thing and having that sense within yourself makes all the difference. Director Imazawa's storyboards and Yamamoto-san's art properly created the stage. The high-density closed space, ship interior atmosphere naturally meant suppressing colour tones and lowering brightness. The basic approach was the same as night interior island colours, but considering the enclosed space colours, screens including characters appeared somewhat harder.

Since performances here also had characters' expressions drawn with sharp distinctions, I think we successfully conveyed the tension of the warship setting throughout the screen.

For this warship, close-ups of interiors and deck were background paintings, but somewhat pulled-back shots and cuts showing the entire warship were all animation. However, even carefully painting cels and building up with special effects couldn't quite convey the warship's size. So what we did was have art staff retouch cel-painted work with paint brushes. So-called BOOK technique. There were quite a few, but precise animation + background texture successfully expressed the warship's size and coldness.

After somehow rescuing Coo from such warships, when humans fire at him, Coo separates from Yosuke and others, departing into the ocean. And Yosuke and others develop protest actions to prevent nuclear testing in waters where Coo's tribe is thought to live. The story heads toward its finale.

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